CHAPTER FOUR

From Textura to Bodoni

The first European types imitated the hand that readers trusted most. When Johannes Gutenberg printed his Bible in Mainz, finished by 1455, he set it in textura, the tall, narrow letter of German choir books, with its broken strokes and diamond feet. The page was meant to pass for a manuscript, and it did: rubricators added the red initials by hand, and some copies were printed on vellum. What was new lay out of sight. Each letter had been cut in steel as a punch, struck into a bar of softer copper to make a matrix, and cast in the hand mould from an alloy of lead, tin and antimony. A single punch could yield thousands of identical sorts, and the whole chain, from punch to page, would stay in use with few changes for nearly four hundred years.

Gutenberg's partners saw the business before he did. Johann Fust took over the shop after a lawsuit in 1455, and with Peter Schoeffer he printed the Mainz Psalter of 1457, the first book to carry a printer's colophon and a date. When Mainz was sacked in 1462 its journeymen scattered, and within twenty years there were presses in more than a hundred towns.

The Venetian roman

Italian readers did not want German letters. The humanists of Florence had revived the Carolingian minuscule for their copies of the classics, a round, open hand they believed ancient, and the printers who came south followed them. The best of the early romans was cut in Venice by Nicolas Jenson, a Frenchman trained at the mint of Tours. His Eusebius of 1470 is set in a roman of even colour and wide, well-fitted capitals, and it has been the model for revivals ever since.

Twenty-five years later Aldus Manutius opened his press in the same city, with a scholar's programme: Greek texts first, then the Latin authors in editions a student could carry. His punchcutter was Francesco Griffo of Bologna. For the short dialogue *De Aetna* by the young Pietro Bembo, printed in 1496,

Griffo cut a roman lighter and more regular than Jenson's, with capitals shorter than the ascenders, the proportion book faces have kept to this day.

In 1501 Aldus issued a Virgil in octavo, set entirely in a new letter: Griffo's italic, based on the sloped script of the papal chancery. It saved space, which suited a pocket book, and it looked learned. The Venetian Senate granted Aldus a privilege over it, counterfeiters in Lyon copied it within a year, and Aldus and Griffo quarrelled over the credit until Griffo left Venice. For a century the italic was a text face in its own right. Only later did printers pair it with a roman and use it for emphasis, titles and foreign words, the role it still has.

Paris and Antwerp

The roman became French in the 1530s. The Paris printer Robert Estienne and his circle wanted Aldine letters, and the man who cut them best was Claude Garamond, a punchcutter who worked mostly for other men's presses. His romans refine Griffo's model: the thin strokes are finer, the serifs sharper, the capitals lighter against the lower case. Between 1540 and 1550 he also cut the *grecs du roi*, three sizes of Greek for François I, closely modelled on the hand of the Cretan scribe Angelos Vergikios.

When Garamond died in 1561 his punches were sold, and many went to Antwerp. Christophe Plantin, a bookbinder from Touraine, had built there the largest printing house in Europe, and he bought type as a banker buys bonds. His shop kept the punches and matrices of Garamond, of Robert Granjon and of Guillaume Le Bé, and for the great Polyglot Bible of 1568–1572, in Latin, Greek, Hebrew, Aramaic and Syriac, he needed all of them. Granjon was the finest italic cutter of the century; he also cut, in Lyon in 1557, the *civilité*, a French secretary hand he hoped would become a national type. It did not, but his italics did. The house stayed with the Moretus family until the city of Antwerp bought it in 1876, and its punches, matrices and account books are still there, the most complete type foundry of its age to survive.

The English century

England printed with Dutch type until the eighteenth century, when an engraver of gun locks set up a foundry in London. William Caslon issued his specimen sheet in 1734, and his roman, sturdy and a little irregular, became the ordinary type of the English-speaking world. It needed no explanation and drew no attention to itself, which is why printers still reach for it.

John Baskerville, a Birmingham writing master who had made his money in japanned ware, came to printing late and changed more than the letters. For his Virgil of 1757 he had his own type cut by John Handy, with a more vertical stress and a sharper contrast than Caslon's, and he printed it on smooth wove paper, with a blacker ink of his own recipe, and pressed the sheets between hot copper plates to give them a gloss. English printers found the pages too bright to read. Readers on the Continent admired them, and a transitional letter, between the old style and the modern, was born.

Measuring type

Until the middle of the eighteenth century every foundry named its sizes as it pleased: *pica*, *cicero*, *long primer*, *petit-romain*. A size was a habit of the house, not a measurement, and a printer who bought type from two foundries could not set it side by side. Pierre-Simon Fournier, the younger son of a Paris family of typefounders, published in 1737 a table of proportions that divided an inch into seventy-two points and gave every body a number of points. He set it out in full in his *Manuel typographique* of 1764–1766. François-Ambroise Didot tied the point to the royal foot about 1783, which made it slightly larger; the Didot point spread across the Continent, while American and British founders settled on a pica point of their own only in 1886 and 1898.

Spanish types

Spanish printers of the early eighteenth century bought their type in Holland and France, and the Crown thought this a disgrace for a kingdom that had printed the Complutensian Polyglot. Charles III and his ministers set out to change it. The Royal Library in Madrid opened a foundry of its own, and the Crown paid pensions to punchcutters who would work in Spain. Two of them came from very different trades.

Eudald Pradell, the son of a gunsmith from Ripoll, had learned to cut steel in his father's forge and cut his first punches in Barcelona. Called to Madrid in 1764 with a royal pension, he cut romans and italics of an open, generous design that the Madrid printers took up at once. Jerónimo Antonio Gil came from the other end of the trade: he was an engraver of the Royal Mint, a medallist, and he cut for the Royal Library a series of romans, italics and Greek that the Library showed in its specimen of 1787. Gil did not stay to see it. In 1778 he left for Mexico as chief engraver of the mint, and there he founded the school that became the Academy of San Carlos.

The printer who made these types famous was Joaquín Ibarra, born in Zaragoza in 1725 and printer to the King from 1779. His Sallust of 1772, translated by the Infante Gabriel, was praised in Paris and Parma for its presswork. For the Real Academia Española he printed in 1780 the *Quixote* in four quarto volumes, set in Gil's types, illustrated by the best engravers of the court and printed on paper made for it in Catalonia. The ink, dark and even, was Ibarra's own; the page, with generous margins and no ornament besides the plates, is the Spanish counterpart of Baskerville's.

Bodoni's moderns

The last step belonged to a printer at a small court. Giambattista Bodoni, born in Saluzzo in 1740, learned to cut punches at the press of the Propaganda Fide in Rome, where he cleaned and set in order its oriental types. In 1768 Duke Ferdinand called him to Parma to run the ducal press, and he stayed there for the rest of his life. His early types follow Fournier; by the 1790s he was cutting letters of a new kind, with hairline serifs, strictly vertical stress and a contrast between thick and thin that only smooth paper and careful printing could hold. These are the modern faces. In Paris, Firmin Didot was drawing the same conclusions at the same time, and the two houses watched each other closely.

Bodoni printed few books that anyone read, and many that everyone admired: Homer in Greek, Horace, Tasso, folio after folio for collectors and kings. His life's work was the *Manuale tipografico*, which his widow, Margherita Dall'Aglio, published in 1818, five years after his death: two volumes of romans and italics in more than a hundred sizes and cuts, with Greek, Hebrew and other alphabets, and a preface that says what a letter ought to be. The modern face swept the Continent and then England, where by 1820 hardly a printer still set books in old-style type.

Names for the families

The words this chapter has used, old style, transitional and modern, come from the printers of the nineteenth century, who needed a way to order their specimen books, and they are not precise. An old style in 1860 meant any letter cut on the model of Caslon; a modern meant anything after Bodoni, however clumsy. The old style came back in the 1840s, when Charles Whittingham of the Chiswick Press reissued Caslon's type for a book set in the manner of

the seventeenth century, and from then on the two lived side by side in every specimen.

In 1921 the French typefounder Francis Thibaudeau proposed to sort types by their serifs alone: triangular, hairline, square or none. It was easy to apply and blind to history. Maximilien Vox, an illustrator and publisher, went further in 1954 with nine families whose names join the masters of each style: *humanes* for the Venetians after Jenson, *garaldes* for Garamond and Aldus, *réales* for the letters of Fournier and Baskerville, *didones* for Didot and Bodoni. The Association Typographique Internationale adopted a version of it in 1962, and the British Standards Institution followed in 1967.

These labels leave out as much as they sort. Gil's romans for the Royal Library are *réales* by the book and Spanish by every other measure; Pradell's italics owe as much to Granjon as to anything cut in their own century. The quarrel between the two ideas of the letter, the one written with a pen and the one drawn with compasses and rule, is older than any of these names and has not been settled.

Letters of Metal, chapter four. Set in Crimson Pro, with Bodoni Moda for display and Libre Franklin for labels (SIL Open Font License). Text written for the Postext Cookbook, CC BY 4.0.

PRINTERS, PUNCHCUTTERS, PATRONS

Index of Names

B

Baskerville, John, **3**
Bembo, Pietro, 1
Bodoni, Giambattista, **4**

C

Caslon, William, **2**
Cervantes, Miguel de, 4
Charles III, king of Spain, 3

D

Dall'Aglio, Margherita, 4
Didot, Firmin, 4
Didot, François-Ambroise, 3

E

Estienne, Robert, 2

F

Fournier, Pierre-Simon, **3**
Fust, Johann, 1

G

Gabriel of Bourbon, Infante, 4
Garamond, Claude, **2**
Gil, Jerónimo Antonio, **3**
Granjon, Robert, **2**
Griffo, Francesco, **1**
Gutenberg, Johannes, **1**

I

Ibarra, Joaquín, **4**

J

Jenson, Nicolas, **1**

M

Manutius, Aldus, **1**

P

Plantin, Christophe, **2**
Pradell, Eudald, **3**

S

Schoeffer, Peter, 1

T

Thibaudeau, Francis, 5

V

Virgil, 2
Vox, Maximilien, 5

W

Whittingham, Charles, 4

Index of Subjects

B

Blackletter
  textura, **1**

C

Classification of types
  Thibaudeau, 1921, 5
  Vox, 1954, **5**
Cursive. *See* Italic

D

De Aetna, 1
Didone. *See* Modern face

F

42-line Bible, **1**
Foundries
  Plantin-Moretus, 2
  Royal Library, Madrid, **3**

G

Garalde. *See* Old style
Greek type, 2

H

Hand mould, 1
Humanist type. *See* Roman type: Venetian

I

Italic, **2**

M

Manuale tipografico, **4**
Manuel typographique, 3
Matrices, 1
Modern face, **4**

O

Old style, **4**

P

Paper, wove, 3
Point system, **3**
Privileges, 2
Punchcutting, **1**. *See also* Matrices

Q

Quixote, Academy edition, **4**

R

Roman type
  Aldine, 2
  Venetian, **1**

S

Specimens
  Caslon, 1734, 2
  Royal Library, 1787, 3

T

Transitional type, 3
Type metal, 1